



BIGFLIX ON BOLLYWOOD HITS

A portly bare-chested fireman sings *Dard-e-Disco*, a demented young man traipses in a *Saawariya* towel. BigFlix sends up Bollywood movies, with love.



PARLE ON REALITY TV

The endless wait, the everready ad breaks. Announcing reality show winners is an exercise in time travel and Parle lampoons it well.



KNOCKING THEM DOWN

★ 1980s: Nirma took on Rin and said it dissolves too quickly

★ 1996: Pepsi came up with 'there's nothing official about it' when Coke was sponsoring the Cricket World Cup

★ 1999: Sprite pushed aside other brands with their tagline 'Bujhaaye pyaas, baki all bakwaas'

★ The Evergreen: *Sholay*'s awesome threesome Gabbar, Jai and Veeru are used, abused, providing humour for all occasions, and all brands

advertising avenues, there is a race to belt out ads every month. "That leads to boredom and in a bid to try something different, advertisers spoof," he adds.

Professionals say the increase in advertising by lifestyle and enjoyment-oriented brands has also led to the step-ups in spoofs. While earlier, detergents and bathing soaps were considered serious products, today these have been replaced by colas, breath fresheners and candies that lend themselves to humour because of their fun character. Sometimes this means making the audience laugh with them as Mentos and Centre Shock do and sometimes it means making viewers chuckle at the competitor's expense like Pepsi did. What makes the ad-

vertisers smirk? The money. While Thums Up spent close to Rs 2 crore on shooting their Kumar car chase in Malaysia, Pepsi aired their version in about Rs 20 lakh.

Viewers have also lightened up and matured, leading advertisers to explore satire. "Earlier the audience was narrow-minded and believed in brawn. But today's youth believes the brain is the only muscle," says Soumitra Karnik, vice-president and executive creative director, JWT, the agency dealing with Pepsi's Youngistan campaign. They seem to have connected with the young target base even before the Kumar spoof could be released, "We had originally posted the ad on Yahoo Pepsizone as is done with all creatives.

But someone downloaded it and put it on YouTube even before the television release," says Hari Krishnan, vice-president, JWT.

But spoofs also have their limitations. Products like an acne cream or a dandruff shampoo are serious consumer products and making fun of them will get the advertiser nowhere. "For instance, you can also never take a chance with celebrities, like Sachin Tendulkar and Amitabh Bachchan as they are icons and the viewers might not take it lightly. People have done it but one has to be very careful," says Pandey. But if it works, it has the whole nation rooting for it. No one minds the wind being taken out of someone else's sails. ■